Tommy Wang

From Nature

Ralph Waldo Emerson (1836) | Reading responses

1. What does Emerson mean by "glad to the brink of fear"?

Emerson feels so much happiness and excitement in nature that the feeling almost becomes frightening. He is not describing an ordinary good mood. Even while crossing an empty field in cold, cloudy weather, he feels overwhelmed by being alive. This suggests that nature can create a powerful feeling of wonder without anything special happening.

2. Summarize Emerson's italicized claims about nature. Do you agree or disagree?

Emerson claims that nature makes people feel young again and restores their reason and faith. In the woods, people can let go of the concerns that come with age and return to a childlike sense of wonder. He also believes nature can repair almost any suffering or loss. I agree that spending time in nature can calm people and help them see their problems differently. However, I do not fully agree that it can repair every hardship. Nature may give someone comfort after a loss, but it cannot replace the person they lost or solve every problem.

3. What does Emerson mean in the underlined section?

When Emerson describes becoming a "transparent eyeball," he means that his usual focus on himself disappears and he becomes completely aware of the world around him. "I am nothing; I see all" shows the difference between losing his ego and gaining a wider view. He feels connected to nature, God, and the "Universal Being" instead of feeling like a separate individual. This is why even social roles and familiar relationships seem less important in that moment.

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4. Paraphrase the feelings nature provokes. Have you ever felt this way?

Emerson says nature makes him feel recognized and connected to something beyond himself. The moving branches seem to greet him, so the woods feel like a living presence rather than an empty place. This connection surprises him while also feeling familiar, and it brings him a better thought or feeling.

Suggested personal response: I can relate to the idea that being in nature can make someone feel calmer and less alone. However, Emerson describes a stronger spiritual connection than I would normally use to explain that feeling.

5. Decode the underlined metaphor. What two things is he comparing?

In "Nature always wears the colors of the spirit," Emerson compares a person's emotions to colors that nature wears like clothing. He means that our mood affects how we see the natural world. When someone feels happy, a landscape may seem bright and beautiful. When that person feels sad, the same landscape may seem gloomy. The scene itself does not have to change for the person's experience of it to change.

6. How does the last section contrast with his earlier statements?

Earlier, Emerson presents nature as a powerful source of happiness and healing. In the last section, he explains that this happiness does not come from nature alone. It also depends on the person and the relationship between the person and nature. Someone grieving a friend may see sadness even in a beautiful landscape. His main point is that nature cannot automatically make everyone happy because people bring their own feelings to what they see.